

D453

Advanced Nursing Skills

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A patient with a chest tube for a pneumothorax, who works as a firefighter and whose wife brought his tablet, has continuous bubbling in the water-seal chamber. Drainage has been 40 mL over the shift. What does this finding suggest?

- A. The lung has fully re-expanded
- B. An air leak in the system or from the patient that needs to be found
- C. Normal tidaling with breathing
- D. Too little drainage, so the tube should be clamped

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A patient's chest tube separates from the drainage unit. What should the nurse do first?

- A. Place the end of the tube in a bottle of sterile water.
- B. Tape the ends back together without cleaning.
- C. Remove the chest tube.
- D. Clamp the tube until a new unit arrives.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

On a 6-second rhythm strip from a patient who teaches high-school biology and is anxious about a test result, the nurse counts 7 QRS complexes. The rhythm is regular. The monitor was replaced yesterday. What is the heart rate?

- A. 42 beats/min
- B. 60 beats/min
- C. 7 beats/min
- D. 70 beats/min

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

On a regular rhythm there are 20 small boxes between R waves. What is the heart rate?

- A.** 15 beats/min
- B.** 75 beats/min
- C.** 20 beats/min
- D.** 30,000 beats/min

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A 64-year-old patient, whose daughter is a paramedic, collapses in the hallway. He is unresponsive and pulseless, and the monitor shows ventricular fibrillation. His dinner tray just arrived. What should happen as soon as possible?

- A.** Wait for his daughter to arrive.
- B.** Synchronized cardioversion
- C.** Start CPR and defibrillate as soon as the defibrillator is ready.
- D.** Give epinephrine and wait to see the rhythm change before shocking.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A pulseless patient's monitor shows asystole in two leads. Which action fits?

- A.** Synchronized cardioversion
- B.** Stop CPR, since the heart has no activity.
- C.** Continue high-quality CPR and give epinephrine.
- D.** Defibrillate at maximum energy.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A ventilated patient, who was a marathon swimmer and whose family brought music for him, triggers a high-pressure alarm. The nurse hears coarse gurgling in his airway. The unit's biomedical tech is on break. What should the nurse do?

- A.** Suction the airway.
- B.** Silence the alarm and recheck later.
- C.** Check for a disconnection in the tubing.
- D.** Wait for the biomedical tech to inspect the machine.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A ventilator sounds a low-pressure alarm. Which cause should the nurse check first?

- A.** A kink in the tubing
- B.** A disconnection or leak in the circuit
- C.** The patient biting the tube
- D.** Secretions in the airway

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

A 55-year-old with heart failure, who owns a flower shop and is still receiving IV diuretics and heart medications, has severe breathlessness and anxiety. Her cardiologist expects she may live several more years. She asks about palliative care. What should the nurse explain?

- A.** Palliative care can manage her symptoms now while she continues her heart treatment.
- B.** She qualifies only when life expectancy is 6 months or less.
- C.** Palliative care is only for patients who are dying.
- D.** She must stop her heart medications to receive palliative care.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

At a bus crash scene on a rainy highway, a nurse doing START triage finds a man who cannot walk. He is breathing 34 times a minute. A news helicopter is overhead. Which tag should he get?

- A.** Green (minor)
- B.** Black (expectant)
- C.** Yellow (delayed)
- D.** Red (immediate)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A nurse on a step-down unit that is short one aide gets four reports at shift change. Which patient should she see first?

- A.** A patient with a stable blood glucose of 180 who wants insulin information
- B.** A patient who called twice for a warm blanket
- C.** A patient with COPD whose baseline saturation is 89%
- D.** A patient 2 hours after surgery whose oxygen saturation just dropped from 96% to 88%

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A new graduate nurse, who finished orientation last week and plans to become a flight nurse, receives an order that she believes is ten times the usual dose. She calls the provider, who says, "Just give it." What should she do next?

- A.** Give half the dose as a compromise.
- B.** Give the dose, because the provider confirmed it.
- C.** Hold the dose and notify the charge nurse or supervisor.
- D.** Refuse and take no further action.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A patient with a chest tube for a pneumothorax, ~~who works as a firefighter and whose wife brought his tablet,~~ has continuous bubbling in the water-seal chamber. ~~Drainage has been 40 mL over the shift.~~ What does this finding suggest?

Target word: meaning of continuous bubbling **Decides:** Continuous water-seal bubbling = air leak.

A	Inverted operation	Re-expansion stops bubbling and tidaling.
B	Correct	Continuous bubbling means air is entering the system.
C	Confusion set	Tidaling is a gentle rise and fall, not continuous bubbling.
D	Camouflage	Uses the drainage amount; clamping is not the fix and can cause a tension pneumothorax.

2. Answer A Concept 1 · transfer

A patient's chest tube separates from the drainage unit. What should the nurse do first?

Target word: reverse: action for disconnection **Decides:** Restore a water seal quickly.

A	Correct	Restores a water seal and keeps air from entering the chest.
B	Adjacent category	Reconnection may happen after, but a seal comes first and contamination is a concern.
C	Inverted operation	Removal is a provider decision and could collapse the lung.
D	Absolute language	Clamping can trap air and cause tension pneumothorax.

3. Answer D Concept 2

On a 6-second rhythm strip from a patient ~~who teaches high school biology and is anxious about a test result,~~ the nurse counts 7 QRS complexes. The rhythm is regular. ~~The monitor was replaced yesterday.~~ What is the heart rate?

Target word: rate **Decides:** 7 complexes × 10.

A	Inverted operation	Multiplies by 6 instead of 10.
B	Dropped element	Drops one complex from the count.
C	Wrong stem number	The raw count, not a rate.
D	Correct	A 6-second strip × 10 gives a minute.

4. Answer B Concept 2 · transfer

On a regular rhythm there are 20 small boxes between R waves. What is the heart rate?

Target word: solve with the small-box method **Decides:** 1,500 ÷ small boxes.

A	Confusion set	Uses 300, the large-box number, with small boxes.
B	Correct	1,500 ÷ 20 = 75.
C	Wrong stem number	The box count used as the rate.
D	Inverted operation	Multiplies instead of dividing.

5. Answer C Concept 3

A 64-year-old patient, ~~whose daughter is a paramedic~~, collapses in the hallway. He is unresponsive and pulseless, and the monitor shows ventricular fibrillation. ~~His dinner tray just arrived.~~ What should happen as soon as possible?

Target word: treatment for VF **Decides:** VF is shockable.

A	Camouflage	Uses the daughter detail and delays life-saving action.
B	Adjacent category	Used for unstable rhythms with a pulse; VF has no QRS to sync to.
C	Correct	Early defibrillation is the key treatment for VF.
D	Inverted operation	Shocking comes first for VF.

6. Answer C Concept 3 • transfer

A pulseless patient's monitor shows asystole in two leads. Which action fits?

Target word: reverse: non-shockable rhythm **Decides:** Asystole is not shocked.

A	Adjacent category	For organized rhythms with a pulse.
B	Absolute language	Resuscitation continues per protocol.
C	Correct	Asystole needs CPR and drugs; shocking a flat line does nothing.
D	Confusion set	Treats asystole like VF.

7. Answer A Concept 4

A ventilated patient, ~~who was a marathon swimmer and whose family brought music for him~~, triggers a high-pressure alarm. The nurse hears coarse gurgling in his airway. ~~The unit's biomedical tech is on break.~~ What should the nurse do?

Target word: respond to high-pressure alarm **Decides:** Gurgling = secretions causing resistance.

A	Correct	Secretions raise airway pressure; clearing them fixes the alarm.
B	Dropped element	Drops the cause, which is still present.
C	Confusion set	Disconnection causes a low-pressure alarm.
D	Camouflage	Uses the tech detail; the patient needs care now.

8. Answer B Concept 4 • transfer

A ventilator sounds a low-pressure alarm. Which cause should the nurse check first?

Target word: reverse: from low-pressure alarm to cause **Decides:** Low pressure = leak or disconnection.

A	Adjacent category	Kinks raise pressure too.
B	Correct	Air escaping lowers pressure.
C	Confusion set	Biting raises pressure.
D	Inverted operation	Secretions raise pressure.

9. Answer A Concept 5

A 55-year-old with heart failure, ~~who owns a flower shop~~ and is still receiving IV diuretics and heart medications, has severe breathlessness and anxiety. Her cardiologist expects she may live several more years. She asks about palliative care. What should the nurse explain?

Target word: palliative care scope **Decides:** Palliative care can be given alongside treatment at any stage.

A	Correct	It is not limited to the end of life.
B	Adjacent category	That is the hospice rule.
C	Absolute language	It is for anyone with serious illness.
D	Confusion set	That describes hospice, not palliative care.

10. Answer D Concept 6

At a bus crash scene ~~on a rainy highway~~, a nurse doing START triage finds a man who cannot walk. He is breathing 34 times a minute. ~~A news helicopter is overhead.~~ Which tag should he get?

Target word: triage tag **Decides:** RR over 30 = immediate.

A	Inverted operation	Green is for people who can walk.
B	Adjacent category	Black is for people not breathing after the airway is opened.
C	Dropped element	Drops the respiratory rate cutoff.
D	Correct	Breathing over 30/min puts him in the immediate group.

11. Answer D Concept 7

A nurse on a step-down unit ~~that is short one aide~~ gets four reports at shift change. Which patient should she see first?

Target word: first patient **Decides:** A new, unexpected, unstable finding.

A	Adjacent category	A teaching need, not an unstable problem.
B	Camouflage	Frequent calls do not make a patient unstable.
C	Confusion set	Low but expected and stable for this patient.
D	Correct	A new drop in oxygenation is unstable and unexpected.

12. Answer C Concept 8

A new graduate nurse, ~~who finished orientation last week and plans to become a flight nurse,~~ receives an order that she believes is ten times the usual dose. She calls the provider, who says, "Just give it." What should she do next?

Target word: next step after unresolved concern **Decides:** Unsafe order not clarified → go up the chain.

A	Adjacent category	Changing a dose on her own is outside her scope.
B	Absolute language	The nurse is accountable for giving an unsafe dose.
C	Correct	The chain of command resolves safety concerns the prescriber dismissed.
D	Dropped element	Drops the duty to escalate so the patient still gets proper care.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	4	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	2	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	8	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	7	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	4	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Closed chest drainage	Gentle rise and fall (tidaling) in the water-seal chamber is expected; continuous bubbling there means an air leak; if the tube disconnects, put its end in sterile water to restore the seal.	Clamping a chest tube for any problem or treating tidaling as a malfunction.	A description of the water-seal chamber or a disconnected tube.
2	Heart rate from an ECG strip	On a 6-second strip, count QRS complexes and multiply by 10; for regular rhythms, $1,500 \div$ small boxes (or $300 \div$ large boxes) between R waves.	Multiplying by 6 or using the box count as the rate.	A strip length or a count of boxes between R waves.
3	Shockable vs. non-shockable rhythms	Ventricular fibrillation and pulseless ventricular tachycardia are shocked; asystole and pulseless electrical activity are not — they get CPR and epinephrine.	Defibrillating a flat line.	A pulseless patient and a named rhythm.
4	Ventilator alarms	High-pressure alarms mean resistance (secretions, biting, kinks, coughing); low-pressure alarms mean a leak or disconnection. If the cause cannot be fixed fast, bag the patient manually.	Silencing an alarm or swapping high- and low-pressure causes.	A ventilator alarm and a bedside finding.
5	Palliative care vs. hospice	Palliative care relieves symptoms at any stage and can run alongside curative treatment; hospice is for a life expectancy of about 6 months or less and focuses on comfort instead of cure.	Thinking palliative care means stopping treatment or is only for the dying.	A seriously ill patient still receiving treatment who wants symptom help.
6	START triage	Walking = green (minor); not breathing after opening the airway = black; breathing over 30/min, capillary refill over 2 seconds, or unable to follow commands = red (immediate); others = yellow (delayed).	Tagging the loudest or most visibly injured patient first.	A mass-casualty scene with breathing rate, refill, or walking status.
7	Prioritizing critically ill patients	See first the patient with an unexpected, unstable change in airway, breathing, or circulation; expected findings and stable chronic problems can wait.	Choosing by diagnosis severity or who called most recently rather than by new instability.	Four patients and “which one first?”

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
8	Chain of command	If an order seems unsafe, clarify with the prescriber; if the concern is not resolved, move up the chain (charge nurse, supervisor) before acting.	Giving the order anyway because the provider insisted, or refusing without escalating.	A questionable order and a dismissive response.

Course scope (public description): Advanced Nursing Skills will build on intermediate skills and focus on advanced skills related to critical care nursing practice, including closed chest drainage systems, electrocardiograms (EKGs), palliative care, ventilators, disaster management and transition to practice. Clinical judgement and problem solving are emphasized in the assessment of critically ill patients and prioritizing patients' needs and nursing interventions. Students are required to be successful on course performance assessments to progress to Adult Health III clinical. Co-requisites: Prerequisite Courses: All prelicensure nursing curriculum courses from previous terms.